

Resilience through the Qur'an: Navigating Grief, Anxiety and Hardship

A summary of the lecture *Building Emotional Resilience through the Qur'an* by Dr. Rania Awaad, explored through the perspective of Islamic spiritual care · Rihlaturruh

Grief, anxiety, loss, disappointment and uncertainty are part of the human experience. A believer, too, may feel overwhelmed, struggle to understand why something is happening, or find it difficult to remain steady when circumstances become heavy.

In her lecture *Building Emotional Resilience through the Qur'an*, Dr. Rania Awaad explored how the Qur'an speaks not only about trials and hardship, but also about human emotions and the ways in which a believer can navigate them.

In this article, I reflect on several insights from her lecture through the perspective of Islamic spiritual care. The stories of the prophets show us that resilience does not mean feeling nothing. Grief, anxiety and frustration are not denied. Rather, the question is how we carry these emotions without losing our connection with Allah.

Remaining rooted when the storm comes

One powerful image used during the lecture was that of a palm tree in a storm. Strong winds may cause the tree to sway from side to side, yet its deep roots prevent it from being easily uprooted.

Spiritual resilience can be understood in a similar way. During difficult periods, we do not have to remain unaffected. We may be deeply touched by what happens. We may grieve. We may experience uncertainty. Resilience does not mean that the storm leaves us untouched; it means remaining rooted despite the storm.

Allah says in the Qur'an:

يُثَبِّتُ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا بِالْقَوْلِ الثَّابِتِ فِي الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ

"Allah makes the believers steadfast with the firm Word in this worldly life and the Hereafter."

(Qur'an 14:27)

The concept of *thabāt* carries the meaning of steadfastness, firmness and stability. It is precisely when circumstances change that we may discover what we are deeply rooted in.

Trials are part of life

The Qur'an does not present worldly life as an existence free from pain or loss. On the contrary:

وَلَنَبْلُوَنَّكُمْ بِشَيْءٍ مِّنَ الْخَوْفِ وَالْجُوعِ وَنَقْصٍ مِّنَ الْأَمْوَالِ وَالْأَنْفُسِ وَالثَّمَرَاتِ ۗ وَبَشِّرِ الصَّابِرِينَ

"We will certainly test you with a touch of fear and famine and loss of property, life and crops. Give good news to those who patiently endure."

(Qur'an 2:155)

Trials differ from one person to another. For one person, the test may concern health; for another, family, marriage, financial difficulties, loss, work or loneliness.

Acknowledging this does not minimise a person's pain. Rather, it reminds us that experiencing a difficult period does not automatically mean that something is wrong with our relationship with Allah.

Grief is not a sign of weak faith

One of the most beautiful examples of this can be found in the story of Prophet Ya' qūb (peace be upon him).

His grief over the loss of his son Yūsuf (peace be upon him) was profound. The Qur'an describes:

وَأَبْيَضَتْ عَيْنَاهُ مِنَ الْحُزْنِ فَهُوَ كَظِيمٌ

"His eyes turned white out of grief, and he suppressed his sorrow."

(Qur'an 12:84)

Ya' qūb grieved and wept. His sorrow did not make him less of a believer. At the same time, his grief remained connected to Allah:

إِنَّمَا أَشْكُو بَيْنِي وَحْزَنِ إِلَى اللَّهِ

"I complain of my anguish and sorrow only to Allah."

(Qur'an 12:86)

There is an important distinction here. A person may turn to Allah and say: "This is difficult. I am grieving. I do not know how to move forward. Help me."

Acknowledging pain is different from turning against Allah or rejecting His decree.

Tears are not the opposite of faith or strength either. Emotional pain does not have to be denied in order to remain spiritually steadfast.

When we do not understand why something happens

In the story of Mūsā (peace be upon him) and al-Khiḍr, we encounter another deeply human experience: struggling with events that do not initially make sense to us.

Mūsā witnesses events that he initially finds difficult to understand and questions what he sees. Only later does it become clear that behind those events was a reality and wisdom he could not yet perceive.

Elsewhere, the Qur'an gives us a principle that resonates with this:

قُلْ إِنَّمَا أَعِظُكُمْ بِمَا أَنَا بَشَرٌ مِّثْلُكُمْ وَأَوَدُّ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَأَطِيعُ أَمْرَهُ

وَعَسَىٰ أَنْ تَكْرَهُوا شَيْئًا وَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَّكُمْ وَعَسَىٰ أَنْ تُحِبُّوا شَيْئًا وَهُوَ شَرٌّ لَّكُمْ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنْتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ

"Perhaps you dislike something which is good for you and like something which is bad for you. Allah knows and you do not know."

(Qur'an 2:216)

This does not mean that every loss must immediately be experienced as something positive. Some events remain deeply painful. The verse does, however, invite us to recognise the limits of our own perception: what I can see today is not necessarily the whole story.

Yūnus (peace be upon him): when life feels constricted

Prophet Yūnus (peace be upon him) also experienced a moment of anger and left his people. Eventually, he found himself surrounded by darkness.

There, he uttered the well-known supplication:

لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ سُبْحَانَكَ إِنِّي كُنْتُ مِنَ الظَّالِمِينَ

"There is no god except You. Glory be to You. I have certainly been among the wrongdoers."

(Qur'an 21:87)

There is a profound movement within this du'ā': Yūnus acknowledges Allah, glorifies Him and then looks honestly at himself.

When life feels constricting, dhikr can become a way of directing our attention back towards Allah.

Anxiety is acknowledged too

During the Hijrah, the Prophet ﷺ and Abū Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) were in the cave while their pursuers were nearby.

The Qur'an preserves the words the Prophet ﷺ spoke to his companion:

لَا تَحْزَنْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَنَا

"Do not grieve; indeed Allah is with us."

(Qur'an 9:40)

The danger did not disappear the moment these words were spoken. The threat remained real. The reassurance lay elsewhere: even within that threatening situation, they were not without Allah.

This is an important aspect of spiritual resilience. Not every difficult circumstance can be changed immediately, but the way we relate to it can be carried by faith, meaning and connection with Allah.

Five sources of spiritual resilience

Five important practices can be drawn from the lecture.

1. Dhikr – continually returning the heart to Allah

Dhikr is more than an act reserved for a particular moment of the day. It can become woven into everyday life: while walking, driving, cooking or carrying out daily tasks.

As the heart becomes accustomed to words such as subḥānAllāh, alḥamdulillāh, lā ḥawla wa lā quwwata illā billāh and innā lillāhi wa innā ilayhi rājiʿ ūn, returning to Allah during difficult moments can become a spiritual habit.

Alongside being an act of worship, dhikr may therefore also be experienced as a moment of stillness, awareness and calm.

2. Ṣabr – actively remaining steadfast

Ṣabr is sometimes understood as simply waiting passively. Yet it also encompasses perseverance, self-restraint and continuing to turn towards Allah during hardship.

Allah says:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلَاةِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ

“O believers! Seek comfort in patience and prayer. Allah is truly with those who are patient.”

(Qur'an 2:153)

The Prophet ﷺ also taught that true patience is particularly significant at the first shock of a calamity.

Ṣabr, therefore, does not mean that pain should not be felt. It concerns how a person continues forward while carrying that pain.

3. Tawakkul – trusting while taking action

Tawakkul can also easily be mistaken for passivity. Trusting Allah, however, does not mean abandoning the appropriate means available to us.

In a well-known narration, a man asks the Prophet ﷺ whether he should tie his camel and trust in Allah, or leave it untied and trust in Allah. The Prophet ﷺ tells him to tie it and place his trust in Allah.

Sometimes this means taking a concrete step ourselves. Sometimes it means asking for advice. At other times, it means recognising that we do not possess certain skills or resources and seeking support from someone who has been trained to provide them.

The Qur'an says:

فَاسْأَلُوا أَهْلَ الذِّكْرِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ

“Ask those who have knowledge if you do not know.”

(Qur'an 16:43)

Within its original context, this verse refers to consulting those who possess knowledge. At the same time, it reminds us of the broader importance of turning to appropriate expertise when our own knowledge is insufficient.

Seeking help therefore does not have to stand in opposition to tawakkul. It can accompany taking responsibility and making use of the means available to us.

4. Shukr – learning to notice what remains

Gratitude does not undo what we have lost. It can, however, help prevent our loss from becoming the only thing we are still able to see.

Allah says:

لَئِنْ شَكَرْتُمْ لَأَزِيدَنَّكُمْ

“If you are grateful, I will certainly give you more.”

(Qur'an 14:7)

One simple exercise mentioned during the lecture was to consciously consider something for which we have never specifically thanked Allah.

It may be something significant, but it may equally be something we normally take for granted: being able to see, breathe, walk, drink water, call someone we love, or simply wake up again in the morning.

Shukr invites us to develop an awareness of what remains present alongside our difficulties.

5. Learning to regulate emotions

The Islamic tradition does not ask us to suppress every emotion. It does, however, teach us that we do not have to immediately act upon every emotional impulse.

When emotions become intense, creating some space between what we feel and how we respond can be helpful.

In contemporary psychology, one aspect of this is described as emotion regulation: not denying an emotion, but learning how to respond to it.

Within the Islamic tradition, we likewise find guidance aimed at helping a person manage their response to strong emotions. The central point is not that anger, grief or anxiety must cease to exist, but that these emotions do not have to take uncontrolled possession of our behaviour.

Faith and professional help do not have to be opposites

An important insight from the lecture is that spiritual resources and professional support do not have to stand in opposition to one another.

A person may not possess every skill needed to navigate every situation independently. We learn some skills within our families. Others may simply never have been available to us.

Seeking help can therefore be part of taking the means Allah has made available.

Within Islamic spiritual care, there is room both for a person's story and for their relationship with Allah. Grief, loss, guilt, anxiety, hope, meaning and faith can all be explored alongside one another.

When psychological or psychiatric treatment is needed, spiritual care can retain its own complementary role. Spiritual guidance does not replace professional mental health care, just as professional treatment does not need to exclude a person's spiritual dimension.

Not unmoved, but deeply rooted

Resilience through the Qur'an ultimately does not mean that a believer will never feel sad, afraid, angry or overwhelmed.

The stories of the prophets show us that human emotions are part of life.

The aim, therefore, is not to become someone who no longer feels. It is to become so deeply rooted that although the storm may move us, it does not completely uproot us.

Dhikr, ṣabr, tawakkul, shukr, ṣalāh, seeking appropriate support and continually returning to Allah can all become sources of strength along that journey.

لَا تَحْزَنْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَنَا

"Do not grieve; indeed Allah is with us."

(Qur'an 9:40)

Source and attribution

This article was written following Dr. Rania Awaad's lecture Building Emotional Resilience through the Qur'an. Key insights from the lecture have been selected and explored here through the perspective of Islamic spiritual care.

Primary sources consulted:

The Qur'an: 2:153, 2:155, 2:216; 9:40; 12:84, 12:86; 14:7, 14:27; 16:43; 21:87.

Al-Bukhārī, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, on patience at the first shock of calamity.

Al-Tirmidhī, Jāmi' al-Tirmidhī, no. 2517, on tying the camel and placing one's trust in Allah.